NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING

Morphological Analysis for Indian Languages

Challenges and solutions in processing Tamil, Hindi, and Telugu

Name: A. Archishman

RegNo: 192425341

Course Code: DSA0311

Course: Natural Language Processing

MORPHOLOGY • WORD STRUCTURE • LANGUAGE TECHNOLOGY

1. What Is Morphological Analysis?

Morphological analysis studies how words are built from smaller meaningful units called morphemes.

Root / Stem

The core part of a word that carries its main meaning.

Example: play

Affixes

Prefixes or suffixes added to a root can change meaning or grammar.

Example: play + ed

Word Analysis

A system identifies the root, suffixes, and grammatical features.

Example: played → play + past

Why it matters in NLP

- Helps computers understand word meaning and grammar.
- Supports search, translation, spell-checking, and text analysis.

2. Why Indian Languages Are Challenging

Tamil, Hindi, and Telugu can express many grammatical details by attaching endings to a word.

Rich Word Forms

One root may appear in many forms to show tense, number, case, or person.

Long Suffix Chains

Several suffixes may combine in one word, making segmentation difficult.

Variation & Ambiguity

Spelling variation, dialects, sandhi, and unknown words can confuse a system.

Language examples

- Tamil: suffixes often mark case and grammatical relationships.
- Hindi: inflection can reflect gender, number, and case.
- Telugu: agglutination can combine a root with multiple suffixes.

3. Methods and Practical Solutions

Rule-Based Analysis

Uses language rules, dictionaries, and suffix lists. Useful when linguistic knowledge is available.

Statistical / Machine Learning

Learns patterns from annotated words and can handle variation better with enough data.

Neural Models

Character-level and transformer models can learn complex word patterns from context.

Combined Approach

Combine rules, dictionaries, and data-driven models for more reliable analysis.

Best practices

- Build larger, high-quality annotated datasets for each language.
- Evaluate on dialects, unseen words, and real-world text.

4. Applications and Conclusion

Morphological analysis is a foundation for many language technologies.

Applications

- Machine translation
- Search engines and information retrieval
- Spell-checking and grammar tools
- Speech recognition and text understanding

Conclusion

- Indian languages have rich and varied word structures.
- Rule-based and AI methods each have strengths.
- Language-specific data and evaluation improve accuracy.

Key takeaway: Better word analysis leads to better NLP for Indian languages.

Thank You


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